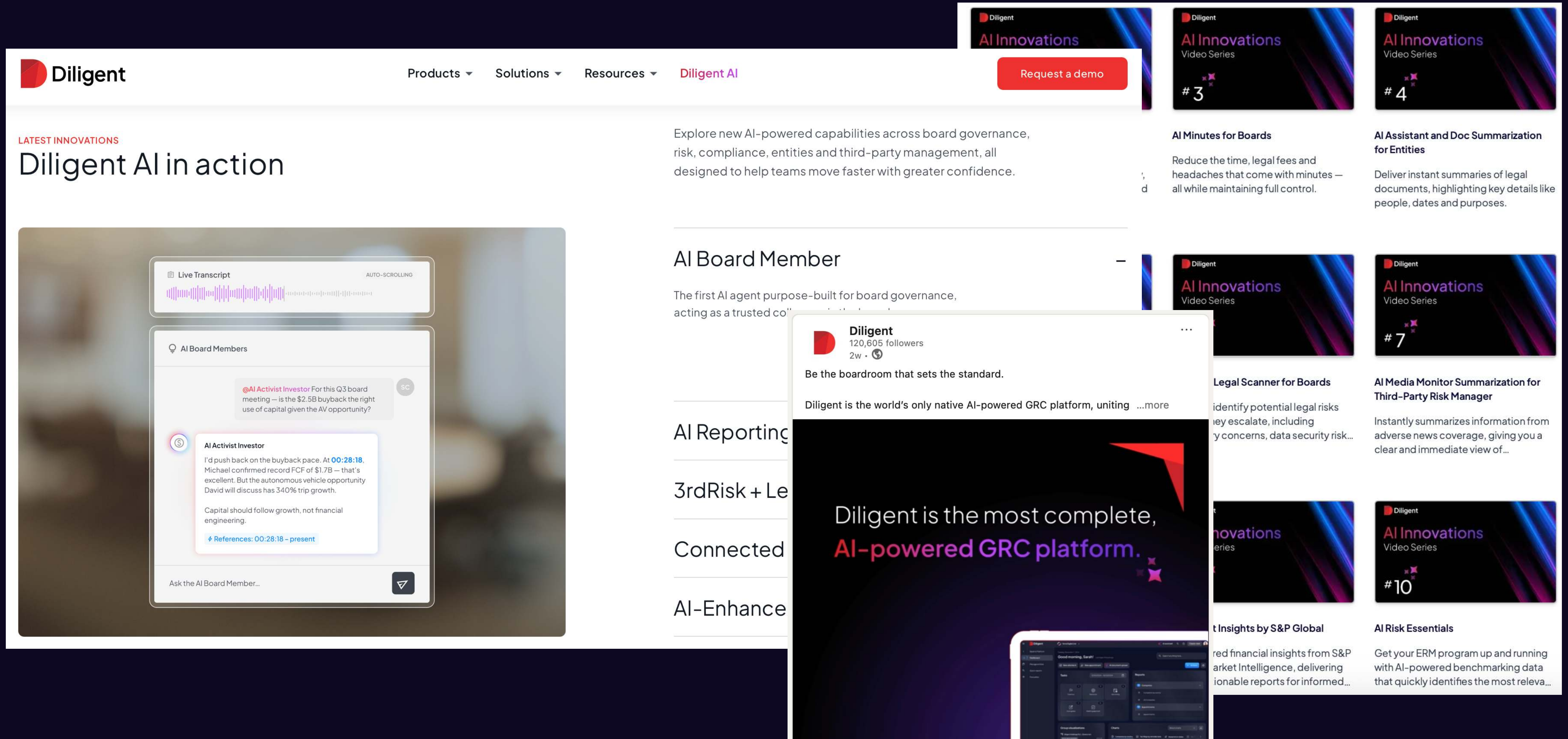


avo.re/compass.pdf

“

We are all in on AI .. not just in our products,
but in the way we operate, support our
clients ... and drive growth.





“

As part of our broader AI strategy, we have decided to add a new section on AI to our performance review framework.





1

CAREER ANXIETY

What happens to me?

2

CAPABILITY ANXIETY

Can I keep up and do it well?

3

CONTROL ANXIETY

Who's really making the decisions here?

4

CREDIBILITY ANXIETY

Can I trust this—and will users trust us?

CAREER ANXIETY

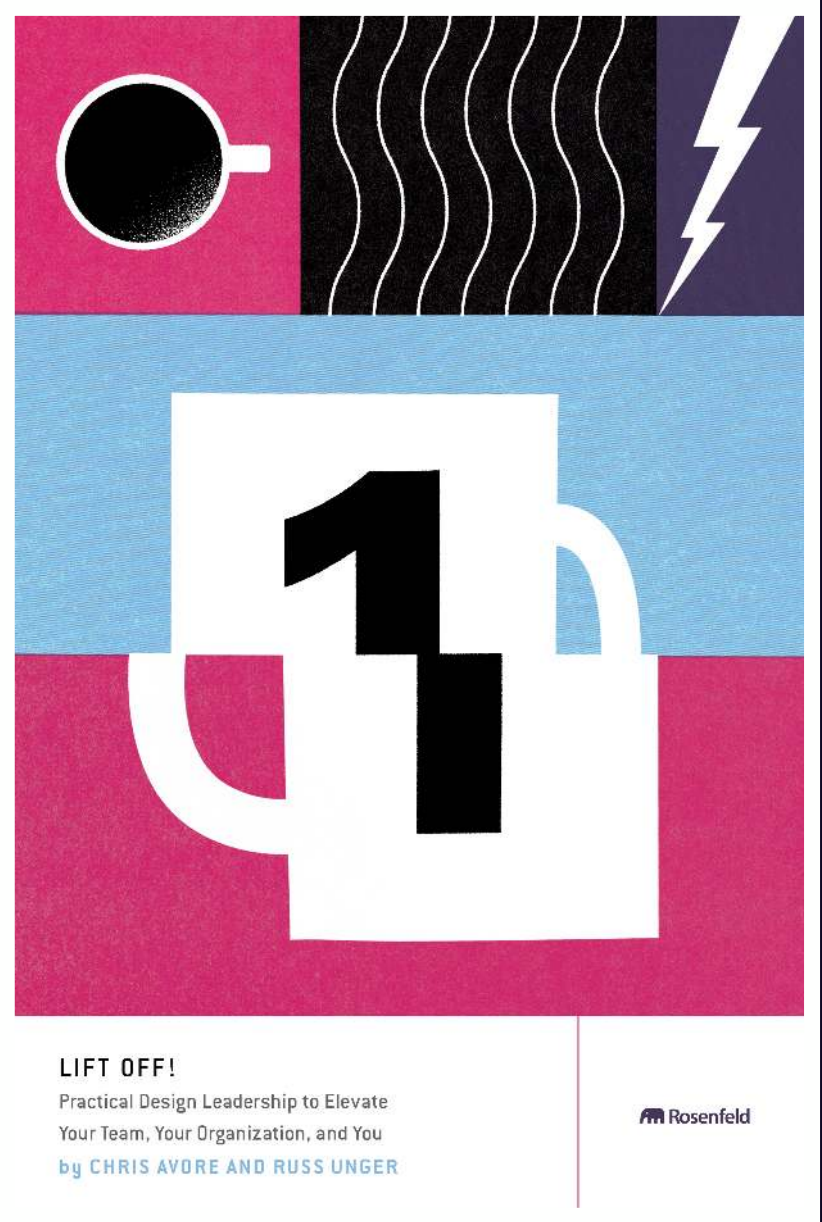
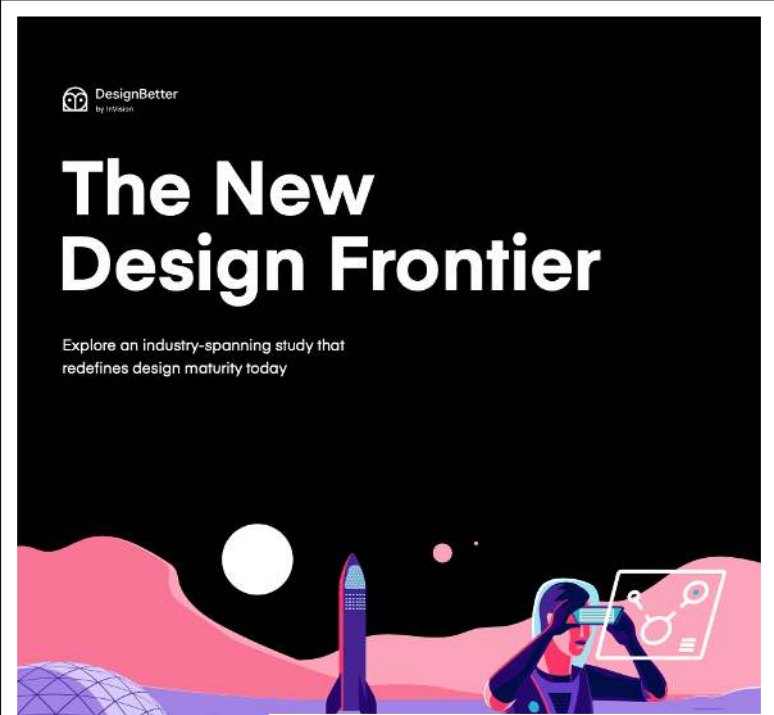
CONTROL ANXIETY

CAPABILITY ANXIETY

CREDIBILITY ANXIETY

2024





Hype

*WHY THE NOISE AROUND
AI MAKES IT HARD TO SEE
WHAT'S REAL.*

Hype

*WHY THE NOISE AROUND
AI MAKES IT HARD TO SEE
WHAT'S REAL.*

Habits

*THE REPEATABLE
PRACTICES THAT TURN AI
FROM HYPE INTO IMPACT.*

Hype

*WHY THE NOISE AROUND
AI MAKES IT HARD TO SEE
WHAT'S REAL.*

Habits

*THE REPEATABLE
PRACTICES THAT TURN AI
FROM HYPE INTO IMPACT.*

Hope

*HOW WE HELP OUR TEAMS
FEEL CONFIDENT AND
OPTIMISTIC ABOUT AI*

The Hype





Business leaders hear an anecdote about an early-stage AI breakthrough, mistake it for a mature use case,

fear that they're missing out,

plunge headlong into adoption — and end up with an implementation that falls short of expectations.

<https://mitsloan.mit.edu/ideas-made-to-matter/how-to-break-ai-hype-cycle-and-make-good-ai-decisions-your-organization>



AI HYPE

1. Overinflated expectations
2. Every competitor move feels urgent
3. Organizational pressure
4. Prototype-to-Product Confusion

CAUSED BY

1. Media & Marketing Amplification
2. Fear of Missing Out
3. Misunderstanding of Capabilities
4. Rapid Accessibility of Tools

TEAMS FEEL

1. "Ship faster without clarity"
2. "Leadership decided; nobody knows why"
3. "We're measuring AI fluency but nobody knows what that means"
4. "Anyone can ship prototypes; nobody owns quality"



WHY BOTHER?

Worse products

AI excitement often masks uncertainty or weak problem framing.

Unengaged burnt-out teams

Hype creates constant urgency and shifting targets that erode teams.

CAREER ANXIETY

AI WILL DO YOUR JOB FASTER AND CHEAPER.

CONTROL ANXIETY

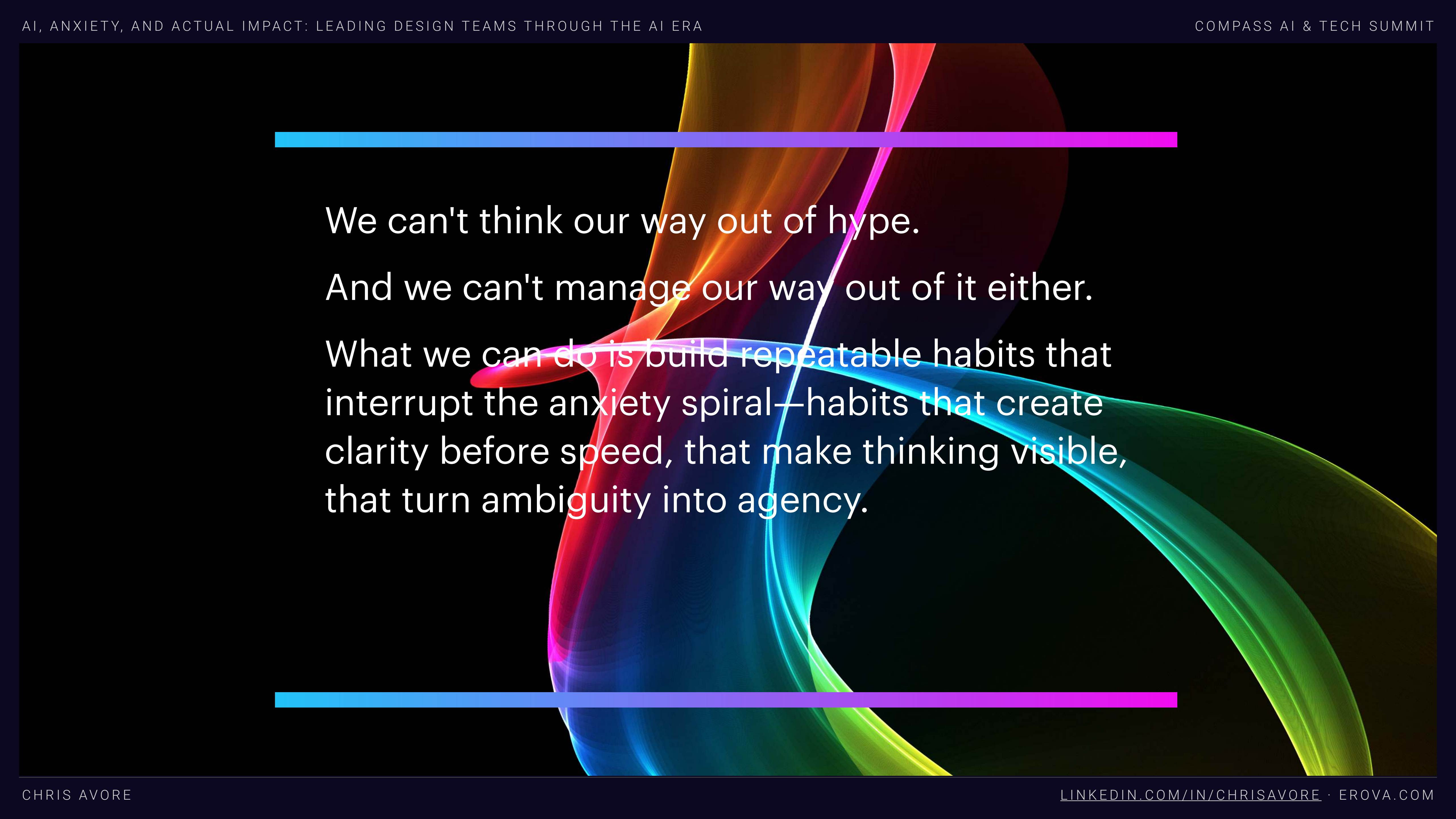
THIS IS HAPPENING NOW. EVERYONE ELSE IS ALREADY HERE. YOU'RE FALLING BEHIND.

CAPABILITY ANXIETY

YOU NEED TO BE AI-READY, AI-FLUENT, AI-INTEGRATED BECAUSE EVERYONE ELSE IS

CREDIBILITY ANXIETY

AI DEMOCRATIZES DESIGN—ANYONE CAN DO DESIGN NOW.



We can't think our way out of hype.
And we can't manage our way out of it either.
What we can do is build repeatable habits that
interrupt the anxiety spiral—habits that create
clarity before speed, that make thinking visible,
that turn ambiguity into agency.



Product Development Process: Pre-AI

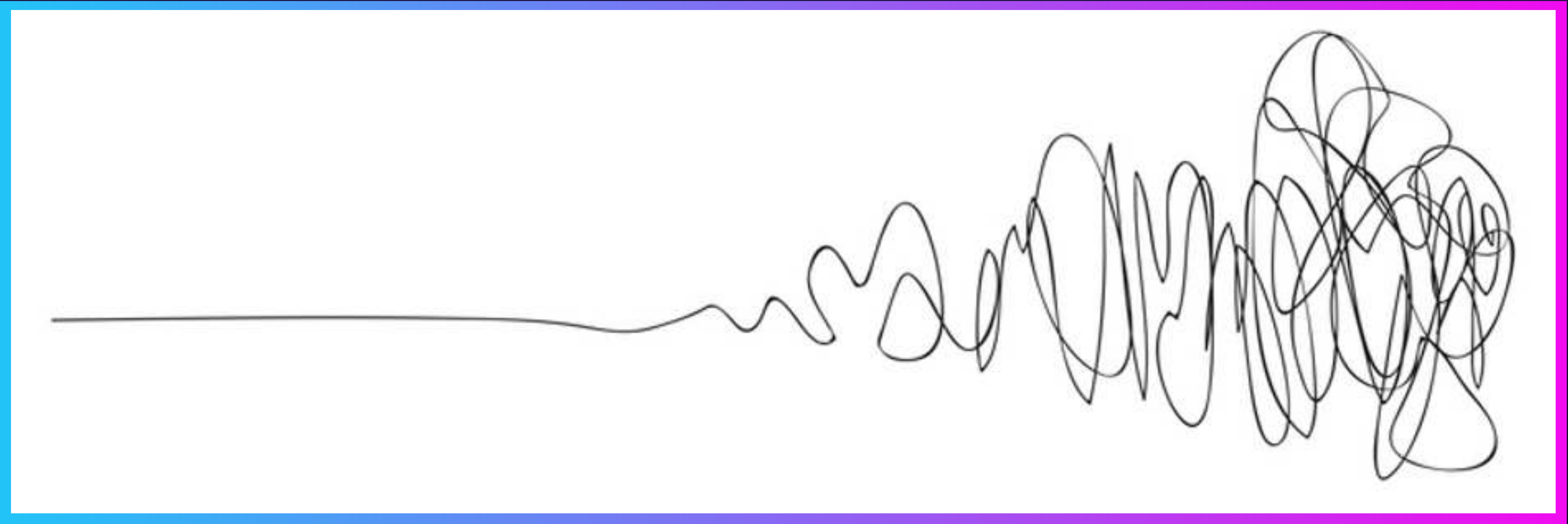


Indecision & Ambiguity

Finding Direction

Aligned Execution

Product Development Process: Using AI Unchecked



High Confidence in
the Solution

Cracks Emerge
in Thinking

Chaos Ensues

The **artifact** can finally **outrun** the team.

/IT'S NEVER BEEN EASIER TO SHIP A TERRIBLE IDEA.

Speed needs better habits.

PROCESS TELLS PEOPLE WHAT TO DO. HABITS MAKE THE RIGHT BEHAVIORS FEEL NATURAL

PROCESS

HABIT

Speed needs better habits.

PROCESS TELLS PEOPLE WHAT TO DO. HABITS MAKE THE RIGHT BEHAVIORS FEEL NATURAL

PROCESS

A defined sequence that teams must follow

HABIT

A repeatable behavior teams use without prompting

Speed needs better habits.

PROCESS TELLS PEOPLE WHAT TO DO. HABITS MAKE THE RIGHT BEHAVIORS FEEL NATURAL

PROCESS

A defined sequence that teams must follow

VS

HABIT

A repeatable behavior teams use without prompting

Speed needs better habits.

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PROCESS

A defined sequence that teams must follow

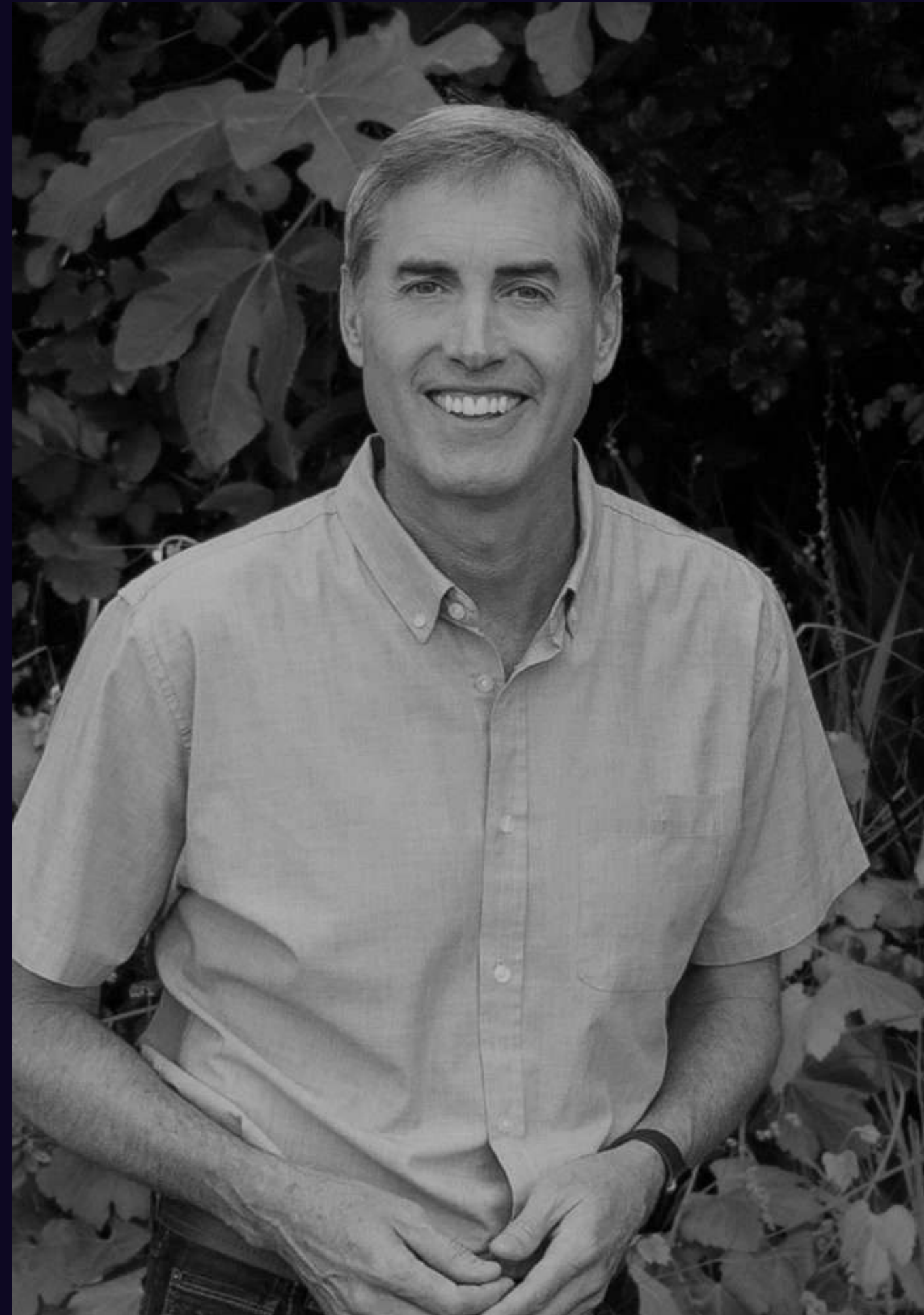


HABIT

A repeatable behavior teams use without prompting



WENDY WOOD, PHD



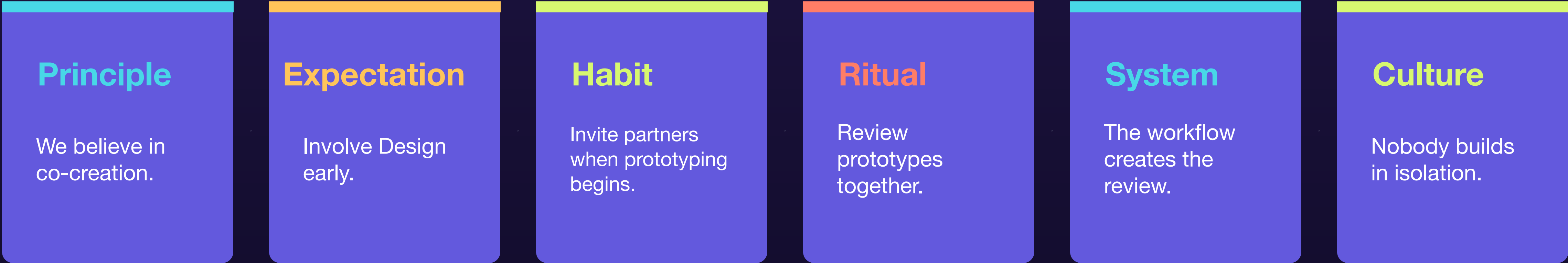
BJ FOGG, PHD



KATY MILKMAN, PHD

Shared principles create positive culture.

PROCESS TELLS PEOPLE WHAT TO DO. HABITS MAKE THE RIGHT BEHAVIORS NATURAL



Shared principles create positive culture.

PROCESS TELLS PEOPLE WHAT TO DO. HABITS MAKE THE RIGHT BEHAVIORS NATURAL

Principle

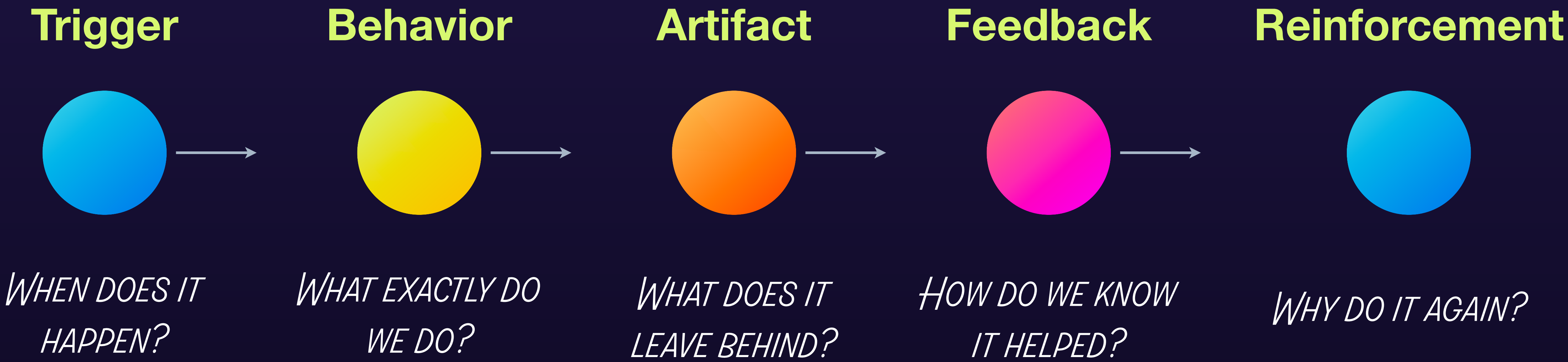
We believe in co-creation.

Culture

Nobody builds in isolation.

Every habit needs a trigger

Design the moment, the behavior, and the proof that it helped.



01

Know your why

State intent before creating.

02

Share early

Make surprises unlikely.

03

Co-create

Work together before handoff.

04

Treat output as hypothesis

Prototype is not product.

05

Close the loop

Capture learning and next steps.

01

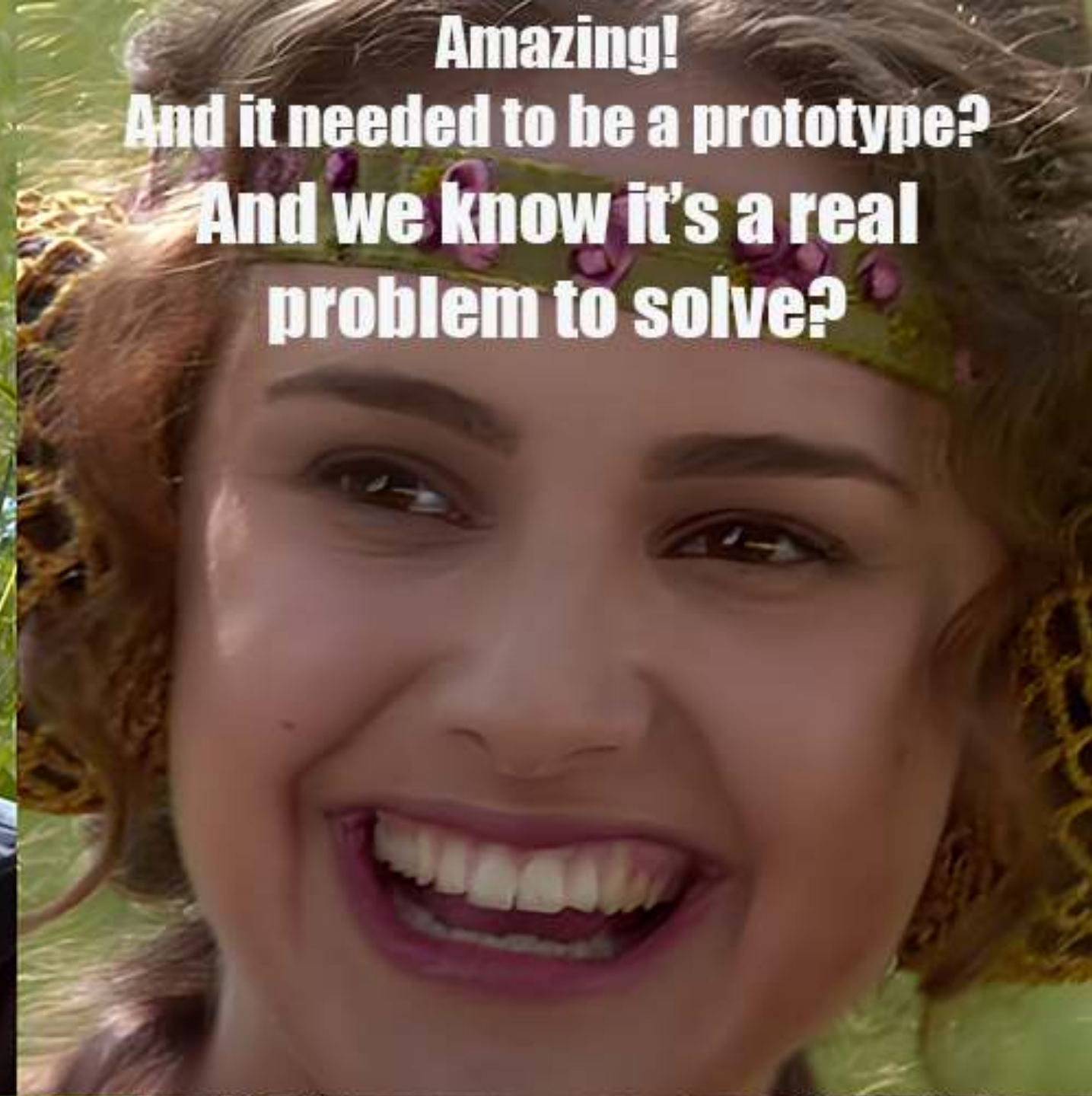
Know your why

State intent before
creating.

- What problem does this prototype solve?
- What fidelity are we targeting?
- What are we betting on?
- Where are guardrails?



**I made this AI prototype
in only one day**



**Amazing!
And it needed to be a prototype?
And we know it's a real
problem to solve?**



I made it in one day.



01

Know your why

State intent before
creating.

- Removes career anxiety:** designers stay in control
- Removes capability anxiety:** clear scope = buildable
- Removes credibility anxiety:** leadership sees rigor
- Removes constraint anxiety:** guardrails are explicit

02

Share early

Make surprises unlikely.

03

Co-create

Work together before handoff.

No Surprises: If prototypes are being shown to leaders or customers & prospects, you should expect Design to have been made aware such a prototype exists.

Operational hygiene: know where it is, how to revise it, what version you're looking at, and know the intent.

AI PLAYBOOK

In Practice

Design Role

Partnership
Expectations

Intent and Limitations

PMs should treat AI-generated prototypes as provocations or thought-starters—not as validated product solutions.

Help frame AI outputs within user-centered design standards. Iterate on the ideas, provide feedback and design direction.

PMs should involve designers early, even with AI tools, to test feasibility and desirability, using prototypes to learn and build confidence.

Understand Fidelity

PMs and designers should clarify the purpose of any prototype (e.g., concept exploration vs. usability validation).

Designers help decide fidelity and feedback methods, guide if a prototype’s needed, and ensure intent fits—just because we can doesn’t mean we should.

PMs should note when they’re prototyping with AI, evolve it for testing, and still provide full SDLC docs—problem, intent, and metrics.

Co-Creation Mindset

AI tools augment, not replace, product or design expertise. Designers should know all PM prototypes to enable true co-creation.

Designers ensure AI ideas align with UX principles, user mental models, existing workflows, systems thinking, and the product’s value.

PMs should involve designers early as co-creators, not decorators, and know AI concepts may differ greatly from what’s ultimately shipped.

Enable Fast, Informed
Iteration

AI can speed idea generation, but teams must still validate assumptions and concepts together before moving forward.

Partner to quantify unknowns, define signals for confidence, script user questions, and co-lead research to shape what and how to test.

PMs involve designers in shaping research, even early. Together, note assumptions, learning goals, methods, and how to act on insights.

02

Share early

Make surprises unlikely.

03

Co-create

Work together before handoff.

Removes credibility anxiety: stakeholders have visibility

Removes capability anxiety: feedback is fast, specific, actionable

Removes career anxiety: designers stay the decision-maker, feedback informs them

Prototypes aren't a substitute for thinking:

Make the reasoning visible.

Enable & expect iteration; nobody is a one-shot AI hero. Let others edit, build on your work.

Align in public, not in private chats or DMs

04

Treat output as hypothesis

Prototype is not product.

05

Close the loop

Capture learning and next steps.

Removes control anxiety: AI proposes, designers decide

Removes credibility anxiety: reasoning is visible, not just output

Removes capability anxiety: learning compounds, nobody starts from zero

Removes career anxiety: judgment, not generation, is the job

04

Treat output as hypothesis

Prototype is not product.

05

Close the loop

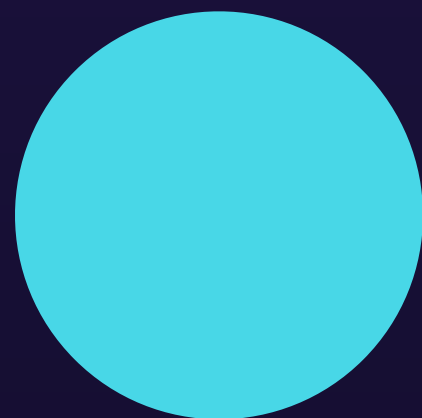
Capture learning and next steps.



Leadership behaviors enable habits to take root.

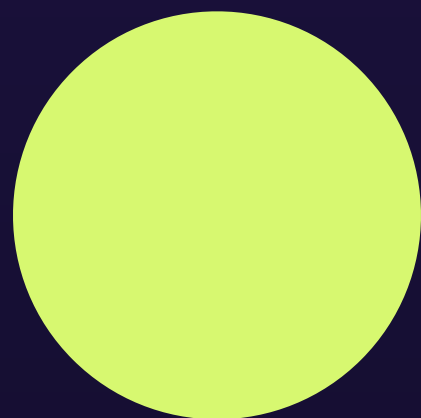
THE QUESTIONS LEADERS KEEP ASKING WILL SHAPE THE BEHAVIORS TEAMS KEEP DOING.

Model



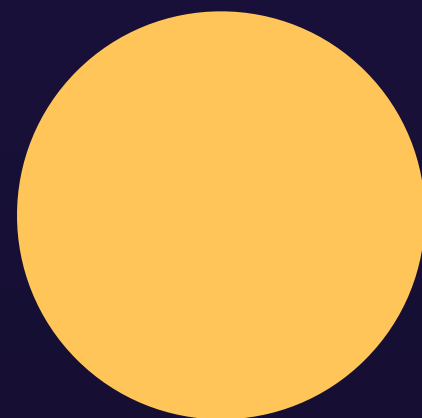
Make your own thinking visible.

Ask



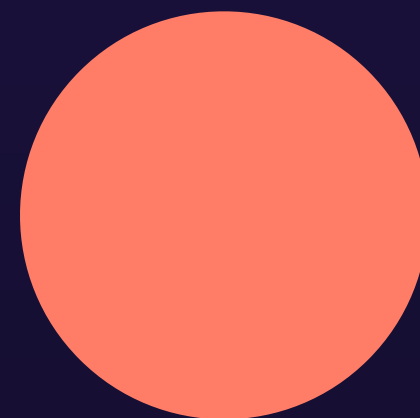
Keep asking for the evidence.

Notice



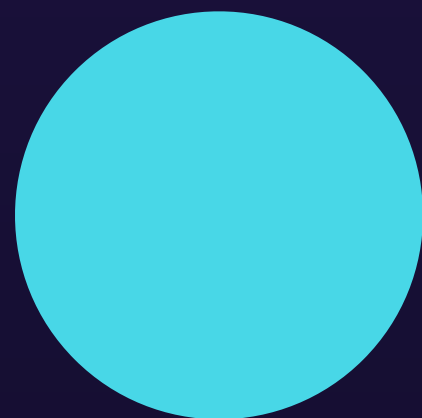
Name the behavior when you see it.

Reinforce



Reward the behavior, not just the outcome.

Model



*HERE'S HOW I TRIED IT TOO.
WHAT AM I MISSING?*

Make your own
thinking visible.

What do we mean when we say ‘use AI’?



	Junior Designer	Mid-Senior Designer	Design Manager
Intent			
Frequency/Adoption			
Complexity of Use			
Autonomy			
Org impact			

	Junior Designer	Mid-Senior Designer	Design Manager
Intent	Learning AI	Integrating, Shaping AI	Governing and multiplying AI
Frequency/Adoption	Daily, as part of individual tasks (e.g., generating first drafts, summarizing research, UI explorations).	Daily-to-weekly, across multiple project phases (research synthesis, prototyping, content strategy, testing prep).	Weekly-to-monthly, selectively for strategy, team enablement, and scaling org impact.
Complexity of Use	Low to moderate: prompt-driven outputs, AI assistants for repetitive or tactical tasks.	Moderate to high: chaining tools (e.g., combining Figma plug-ins, GPT prototypes, analytics), editing raw AI outputs into production-quality work.	High: evaluating workflows across tools, piloting agentic design patterns, identifying enterprise-scale integrations.
Autonomy	Mostly guided: learning how to use AI responsibly, under senior oversight.	Semi-independent: adapting AI to project needs, validating outputs with critical design judgment.	Independent and directive: defining guidelines, governance, and best practices for the org.
Org impact	Individual productivity gains.	Project-level efficiency and quality improvements.	Org-wide impact: shaping AI adoption strategy, addressing AI anxiety, setting standards, ensuring ethical use.

Associate Designer

Uses AI to complete tasks faster without losing quality.
Shows curiosity, experiments, documents learnings.

Mid Designer

Consistently integrates AI into design phases.
Improves project outcomes (breadth of exploration, speed of delivery).

Senior Designer

Leads by example in crafting AI-enhanced workflows.
Mentors peers, shares reusable practices.

Design Manager

Demonstrates org-level impact (efficiency, adoption, reduced churn).
Shapes vision for AI in design practice, balances ethics, value, and culture.

Ask



*HOW CAN WE KNOW WE'RE RIGHT?
WHERE AND HOW CAN WE GATHER
SIGNAL & CONVICTION?*

Keep asking for the
evidence.

*WHAT DID YOU LEARN THAT SURPRISED YOU?
HOW DID SWITCHING MODELS HELP?*

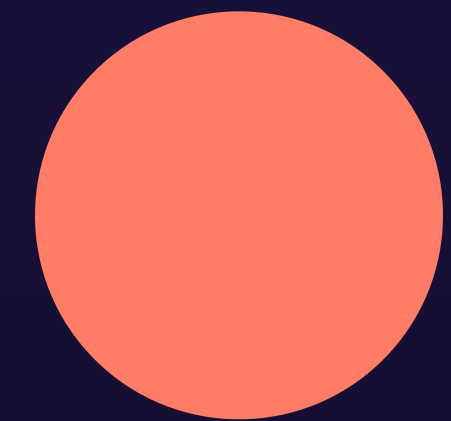
Notice



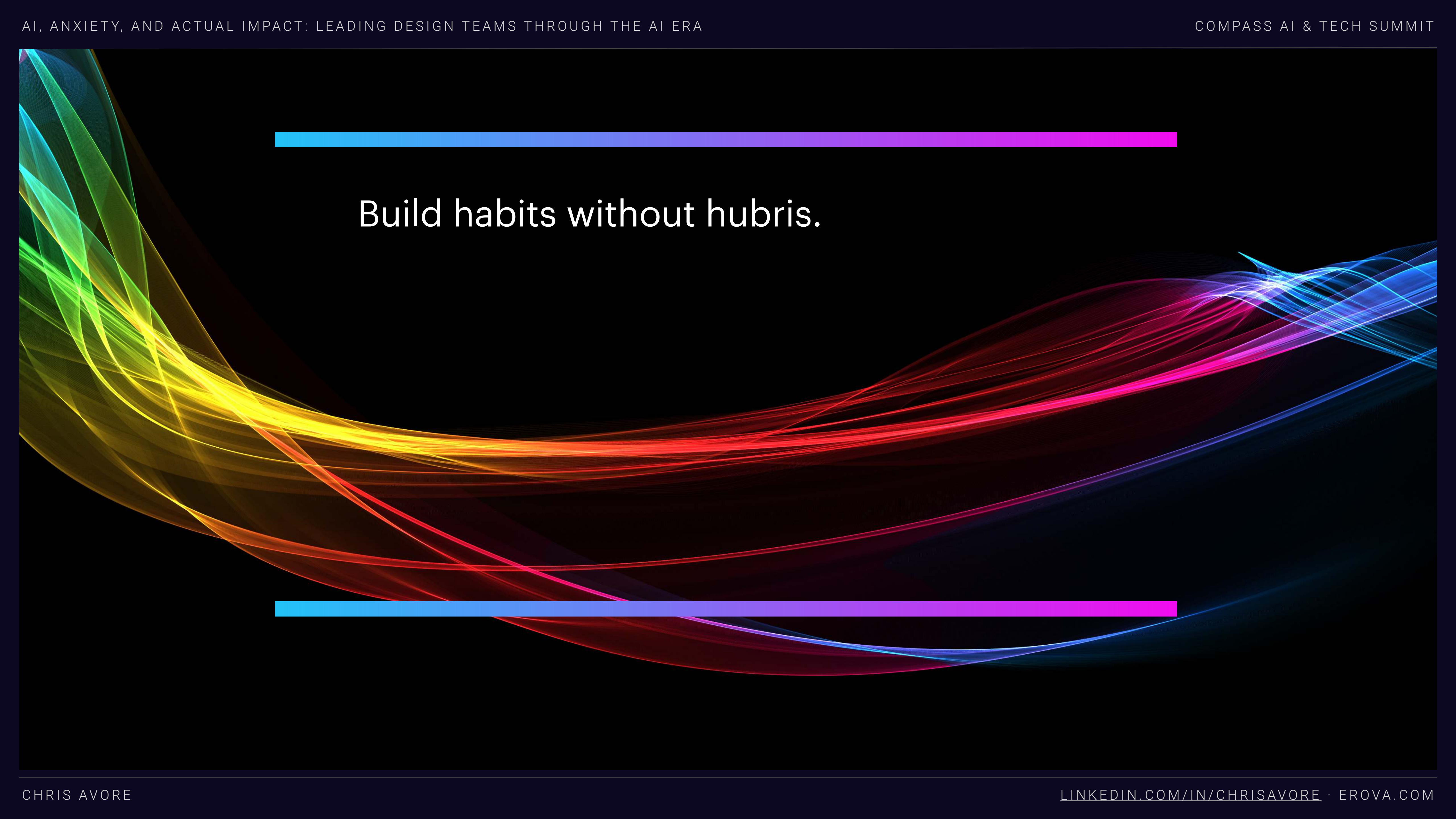
Name the behavior
when you see it.

*WHAT DID YOU LEARN, EVEN IF IT DIDN'T WORK?
WHO DID YOU BRING IN EARLY,
AND WHAT CHANGED BECAUSE OF IT?*

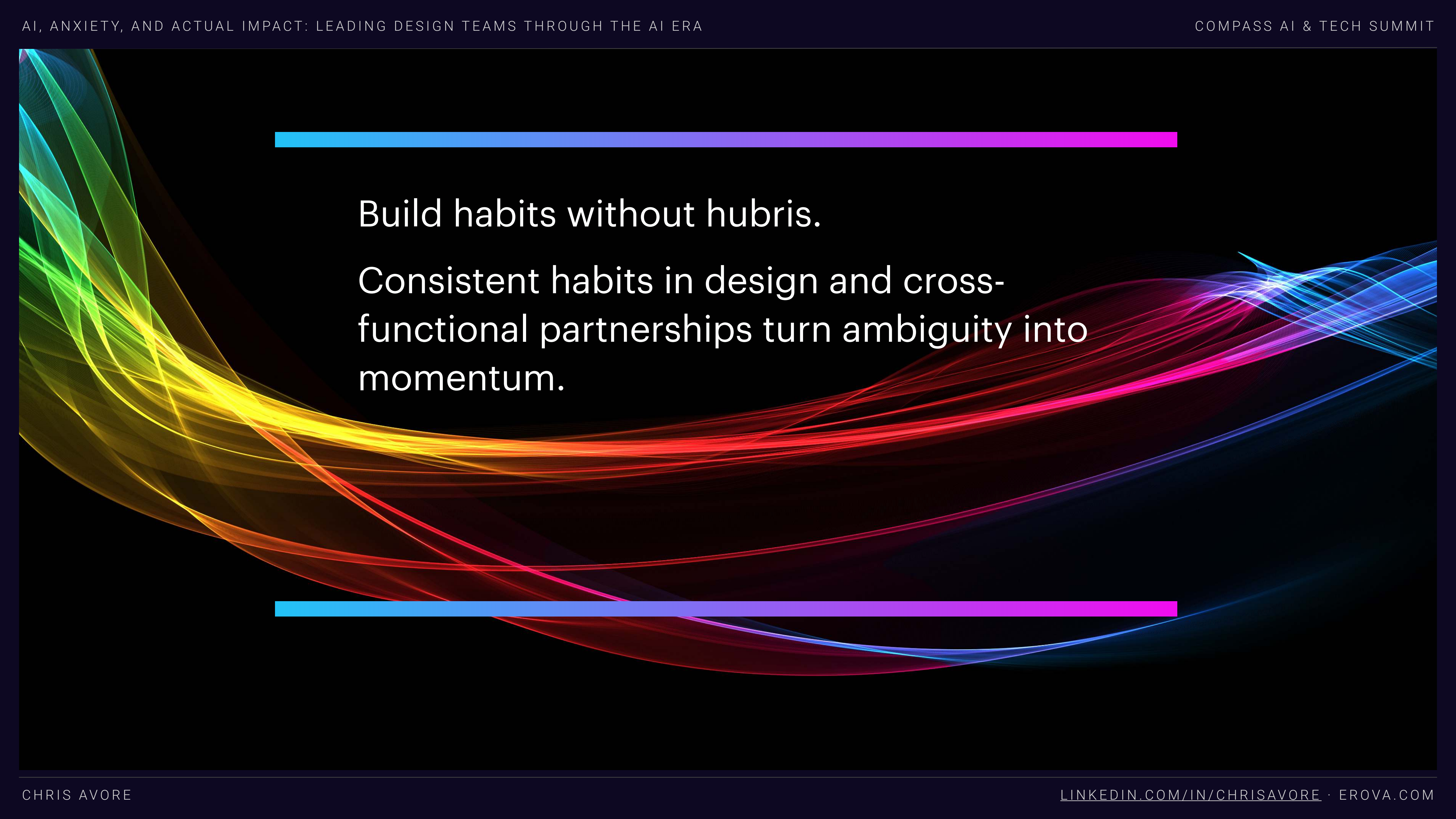
Reinforce



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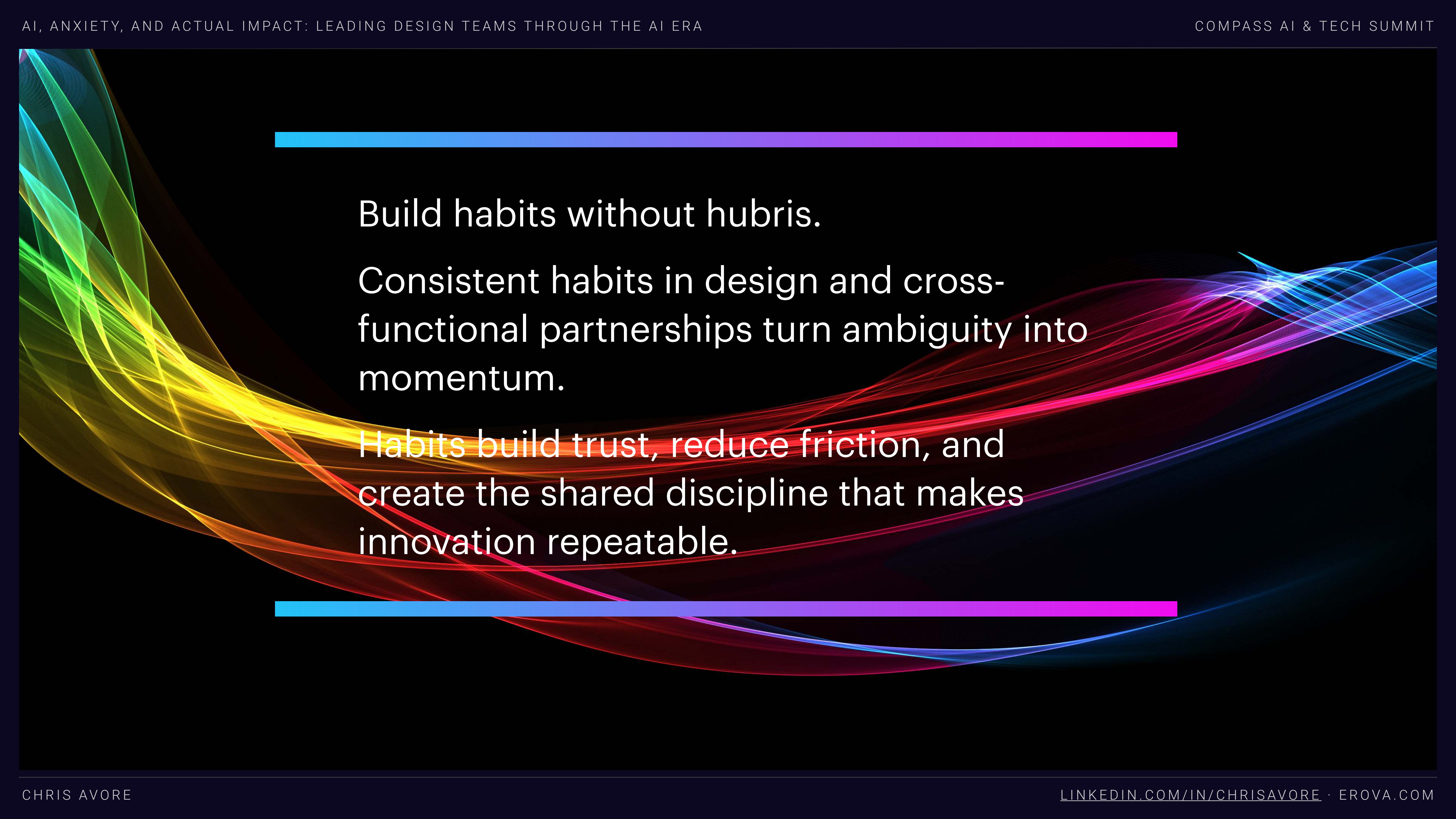
The background features a dark field with vibrant, multi-colored lines (yellow, orange, red, pink, blue, green) that flow and swirl across the frame, creating a sense of motion and energy. Two horizontal bars, one at the top and one at the bottom, have a color gradient from light blue on the left to magenta on the right.

Build habits without hubris.

The background features a dark blue gradient with vibrant, multi-colored flowing lines in shades of green, yellow, orange, red, and blue that sweep across the frame. Two horizontal bars, one at the top and one at the bottom, transition from light blue on the left to magenta on the right.

Build habits without hubris.

Consistent habits in design and cross-functional partnerships turn ambiguity into momentum.

The background features a dark blue gradient with vibrant, multi-colored flowing lines in shades of green, yellow, orange, red, and blue that sweep across the frame. Two horizontal bars, one blue and one purple, are positioned above and below the main text blocks.

Build habits without hubris.

Consistent habits in design and cross-functional partnerships turn ambiguity into momentum.

Habits build trust, reduce friction, and create the shared discipline that makes innovation repeatable.

The Hope

CAREER ANXIETY

CONTROL ANXIETY

CAPABILITY ANXIETY

CREDIBILITY ANXIETY

62%

workers fearing AI
would negatively
impact their jobs

< 30%

had received any
training to use AI tools

Deloitte survey, 2023

2023

Deloitte survey, 2023

60%

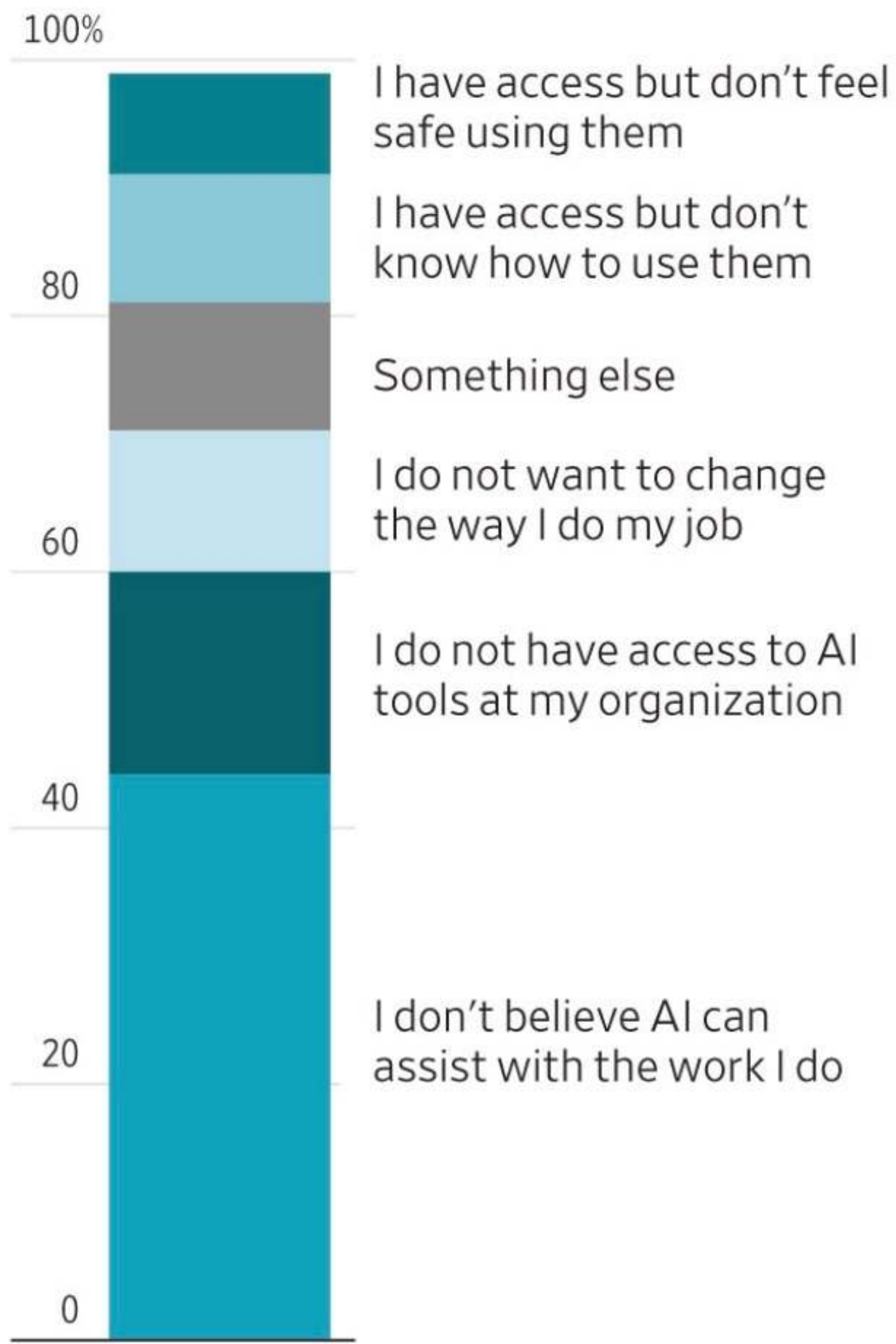
workers fearing AI
would negatively
impact their jobs

< 35%

had received any
training to use AI tools

Mercer Global Talent Trends & JFF 2026

Share of responses from U.S. workers who don't use AI tools when asked to select the main reason why not



I have access but don't feel safe using them

I have access but don't know how to use them

I do not want to change the way I do my job

I do not have access to AI tools at my organization

I don't believe AI can assist with the work I do

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The Boss Has a Message: Use AI or You’re Fired

At companies big and small, employees have feared being replaced by AI. The new threat: Being replaced by someone who knows AI.

2025

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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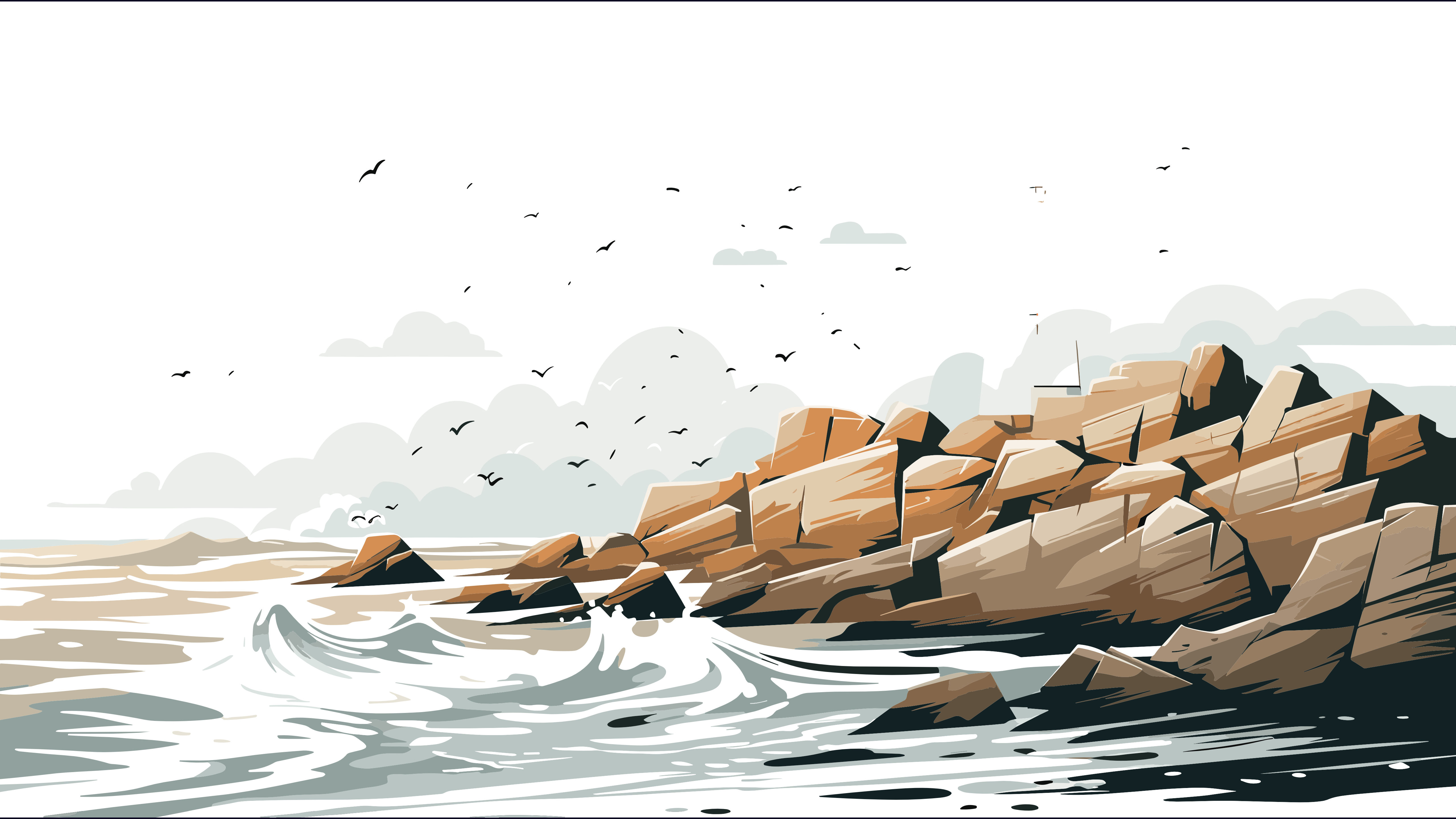
2025

BUSINESS

Corporate America Has Suddenly Decided to Stop Blowing Money on AI

Companies big and small are mixing models and it’s changing the economics and power players of the industry

2026







Anchor the team in **purpose**, not just tools



Anchor the team in **purpose**, not just tools
Give people **agency** to explore safely



Anchor the team in **purpose**, not just tools

Give people **agency** to explore safely

Reframe AI as a creative & operational amplifier



Anchor the team in **purpose**, not just tools

Give people **agency** to explore safely

Reframe AI as a creative & operational amplifier

Make **progress visible**, even in small steps



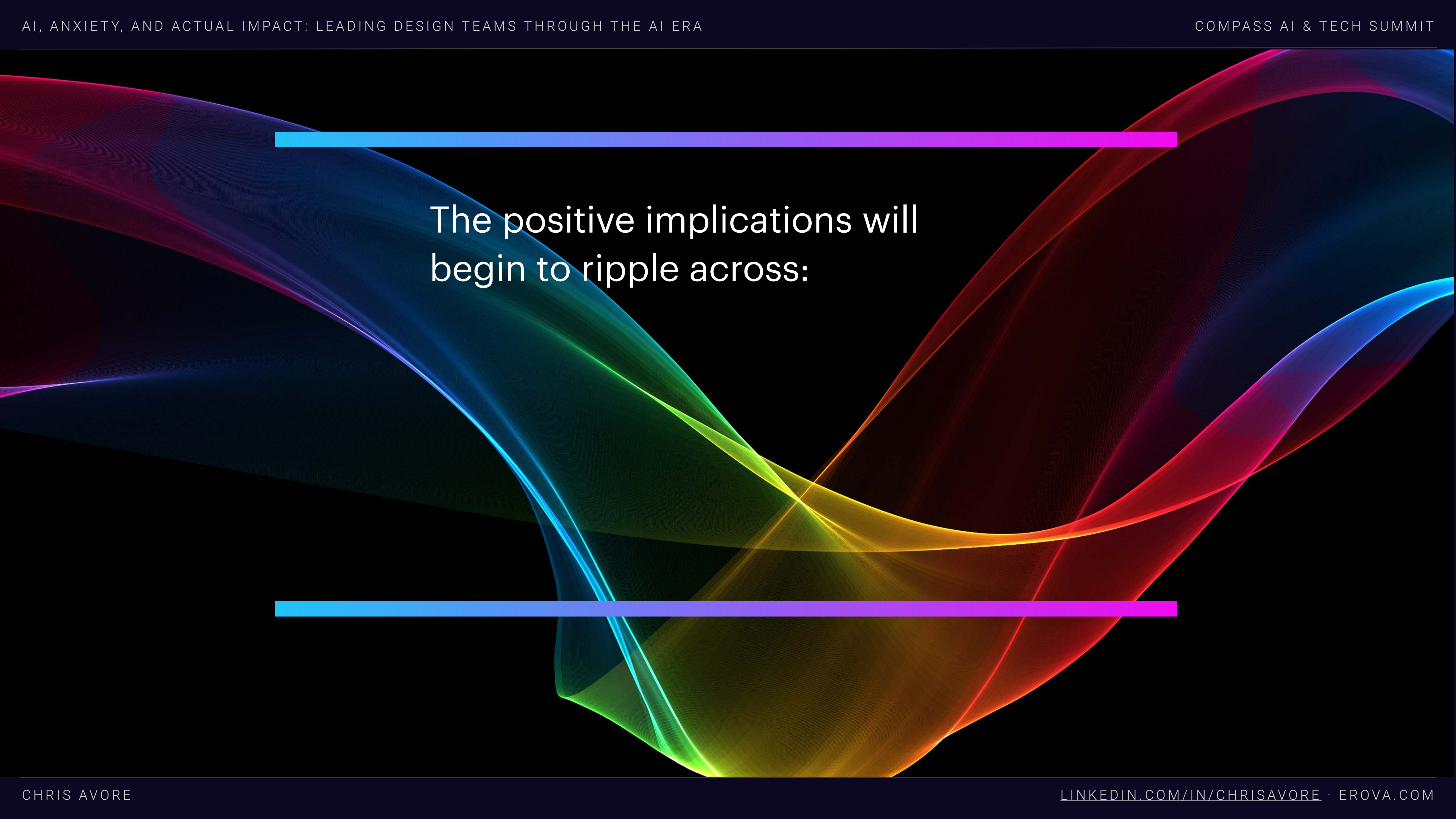
Anchor the team in **purpose**, not just tools

Give people **agency** to explore safely

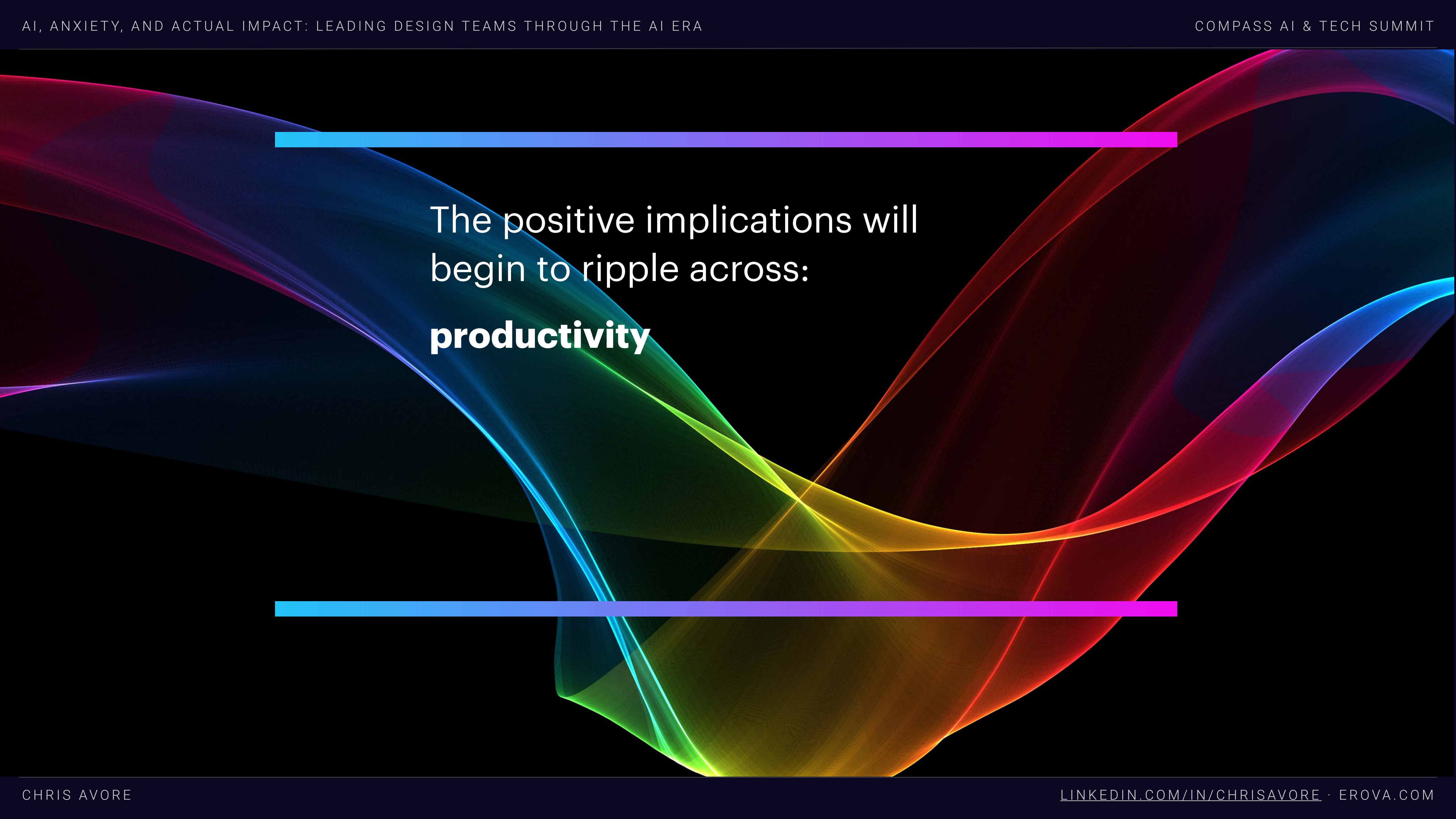
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Make **progress visible**, even in small steps

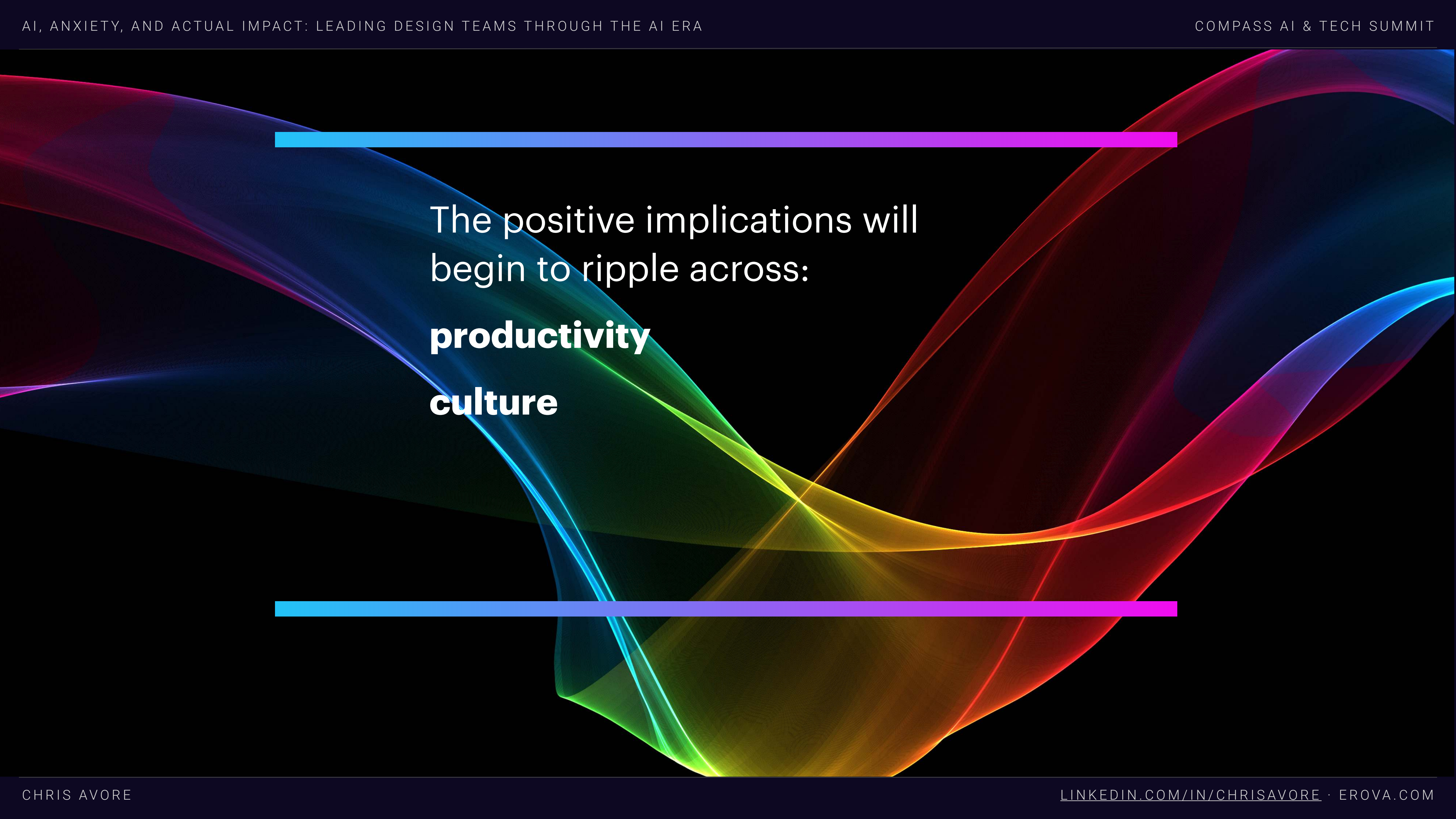
Be **transparent** and **intentional** when talking about AI



The positive implications will
begin to ripple across:



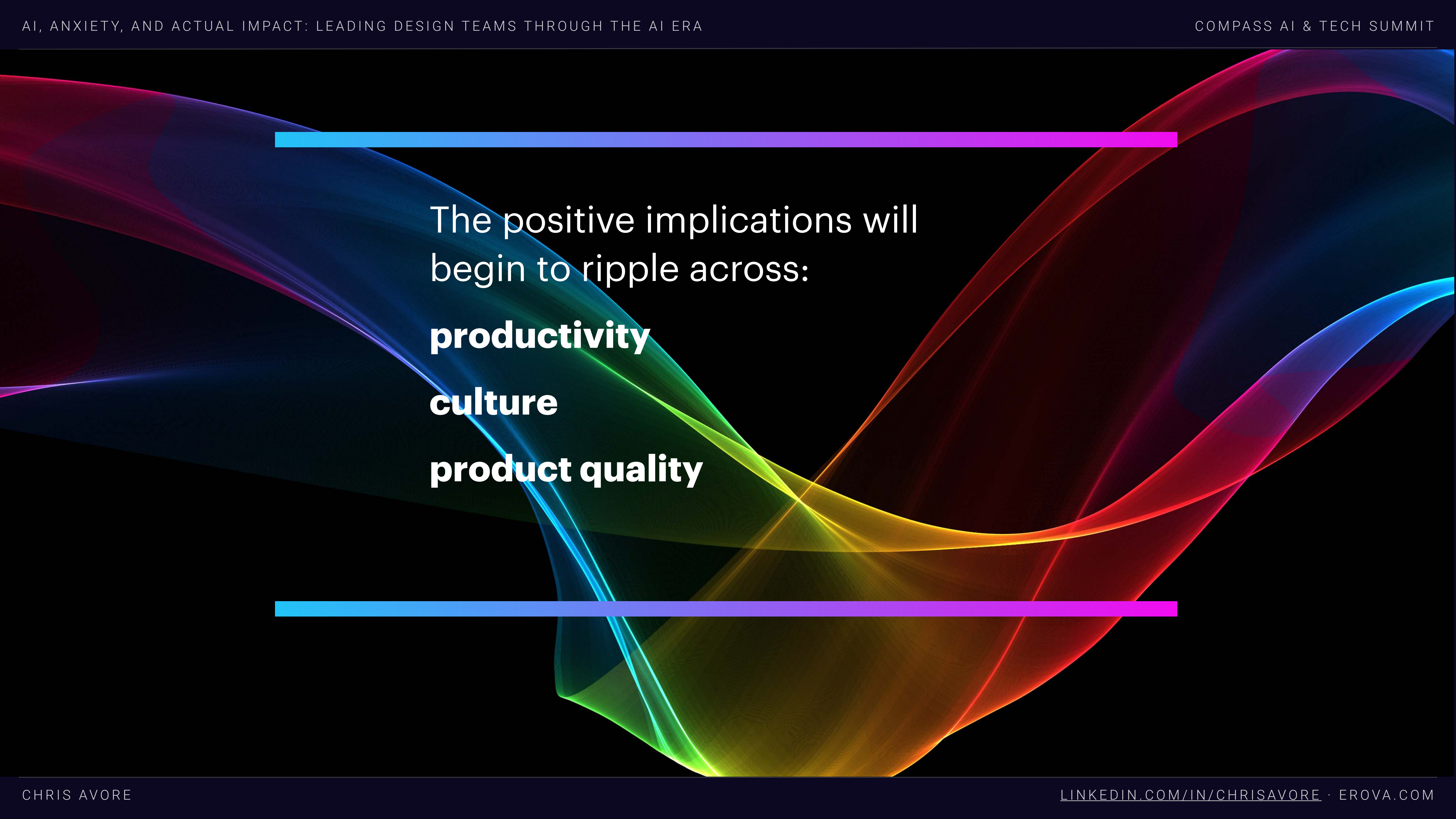
The positive implications will
begin to ripple across:
productivity



The positive implications will
begin to ripple across:

productivity

culture

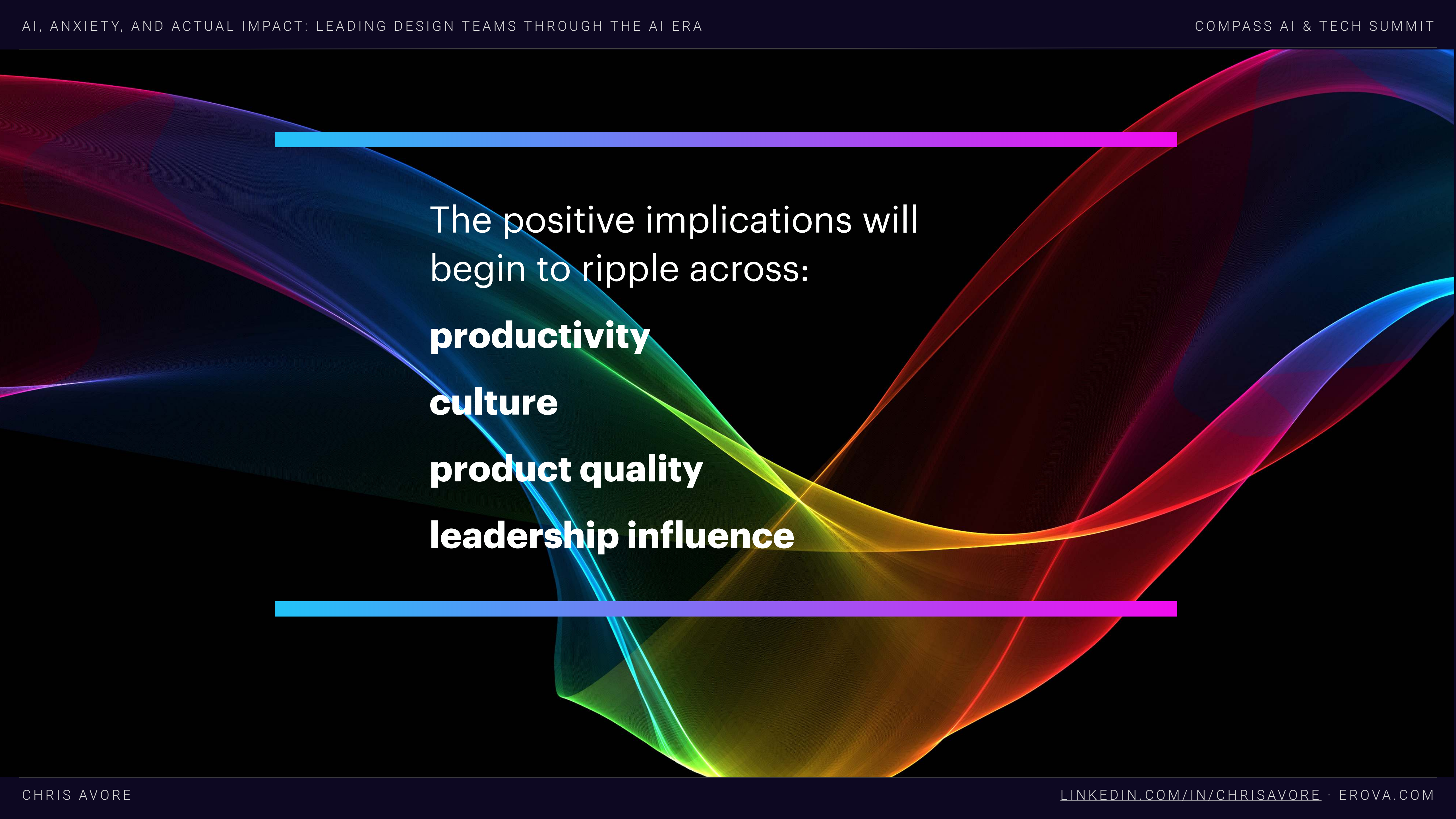


The positive implications will
begin to ripple across:

productivity

culture

product quality



The positive implications will
begin to ripple across:

productivity

culture

product quality

leadership influence



Hype

Habits

Hope

Hype

/INDUCES ANXIETY

Habits

Hope

Hype

INDUCES ANXIETY

Habits

NAVIGATE A PATH FORWARD

Hope

Hype

INDUCES ANXIETY

Habits

NAVIGATE A PATH FORWARD

Hope

DESIGNS A BETTER FUTURE



DESIGN TEAM
IMPLICATIONS

Higher Creative
Confidence

Focus on Craft
and Strategy

Shared Language &
Playbooks

PRODUCT & PROCESS

IMPLICATIONS

Faster Cycles,
More Exploration

Higher Quality
Insights

AI-Native Patterns
in Products

ORGANIZATIONAL IMPLICATIONS

Reduced Resistance,
Increased Adoption

Design as a
Change Leader

Talent Magnet &
Improved Retention

ANXIETY

*SLOWS ADOPTION AND DRAGS
ENERGY TOWARD SURVIVAL*

ANXIETY

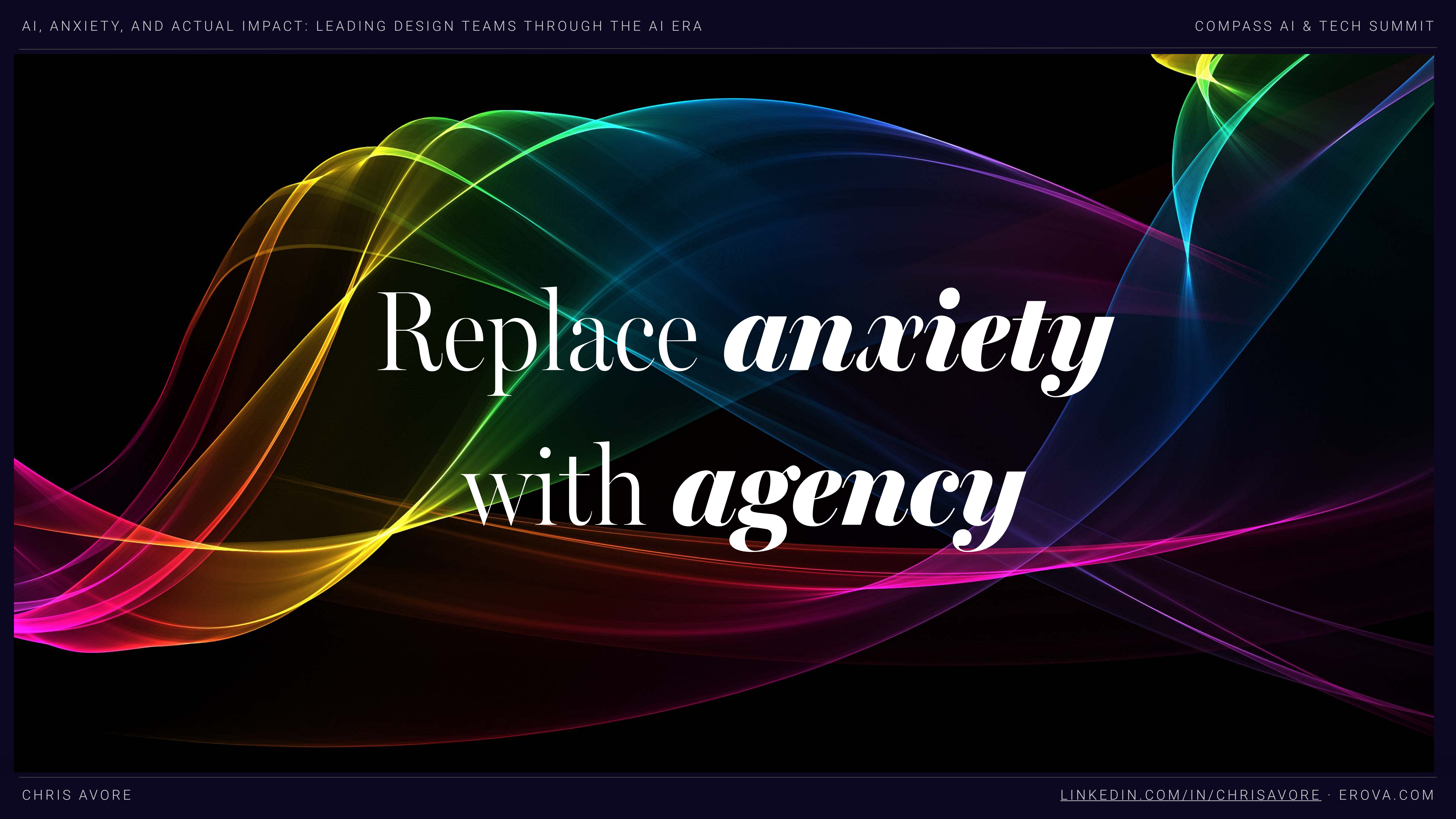
*SLOWS ADOPTION AND DRAGS
ENERGY TOWARD SURVIVAL*

CONFIDENCE ACCELERATES MATURITY

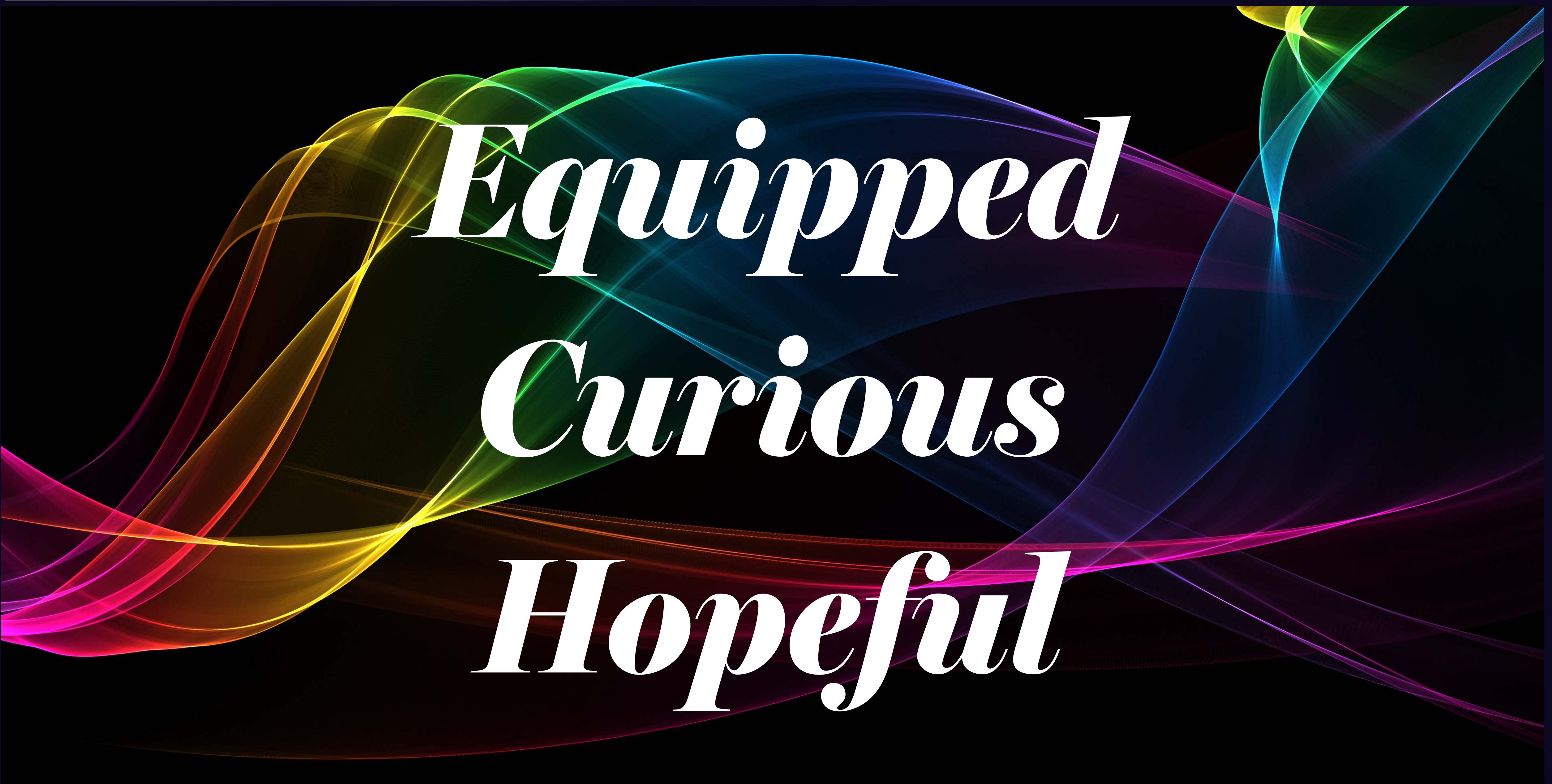
*THE TEAM BECOMES A
MULTIPLIER OF AI VALUE.*



Replace *anxiety*



Replace *anxiety*
with *agency*



Equipped Curious Hopeful



How will *you* reduce anxiety and unlock hope in how your teams use AI?

CHRIS AVORE

[LINKEDIN.COM/IN/CHRISAVORE](https://www.linkedin.com/in/chrisavore)

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[AVO.RE/COMPASS.PDF](https://avo.re/compass.pdf)